

some clients have family members or partners who are more troubled, chaotic, and self-destructive than they are, in which case therapy needs to help the client create new boundaries and support parentified or desperate young parts. This is particularly true in families that have little or no apparent interest in recovery, where the client faces wrath, derision, or exile if they choose a more settled, manager-led life. While distressed families deserve an equal measure of compassion, the client has an obligation to free their parentified young rescuers from an impossible task.

Our job is to help clients explore their relational network, including outside pressures and obligations, so we can clarify external polarities that activate and impact their compulsive behaviors. How does the client spend their day? Whom do they see? What are those relationships like? What we often find is that a client's firefighters are polarized with the manager parts of a partner, a parent, or some authority figure, which bolsters their determination and hinders the client's access to manager parts.

QUESTIONS FOR CLIENTS ABOUT OUTSIDE INFLUENCES

- How much does _____ know about your substance use (or bulimia, gambling, or other patterns of compulsive behavior)?
- How much information do you feel safe sharing with them?
- What do you *not* want to share with them?
- What are you afraid would happen if they knew everything?
- Have their opinions or feelings about this behavior changed over time?
- Do you and _____ argue about this compulsive behavior?
- Does _____ have a compulsive habit that worries you?
- When _____ complains about your behavior, how do you respond?
- How does your response impact the relationship?
- If your relationship with _____ was good, what would it look like?
- Do you and _____ engage in this behavior together? If yes, what is that like for you?
- If you stopped this compulsion, how would that impact _____?
- If _____ stopped their compulsion, how would that impact you?
- Have you shared your vision or plan about your addictive behavior with _____?
- Do you know what plan or vision _____ has for their compulsive behavior?
- Do you feel you can speak honestly with _____ about your plan?

- Do you have fears about the relationship ending if you make changes?

BEFRIENDING MANAGERS

If you aren't already engaging in shuttle diplomacy between firefighters and managers as you complete the firefighter history review, it's important to go back to the manager team. Negotiating with these more socially astute parts may seem counterintuitive, but their shaming is what motivates firefighters to engage in compulsive practices. Therefore, if managers calm down, firefighters are much more likely to cooperate. As you turn to managers, your first aim is to befriend them, which requires understanding their motives and concerns. Here is a rundown of what you need to know about managers.

1. **Managers take care of business.** This team puts the highest value on task completion and personal effort. They work diligently to maintain stability, they strive to meet the client's relational needs, and they revere personal growth. They encourage people to take on new challenges, and they foster maturity. However, their desire for progress can turn them into pitiless critics when they fear life is careening downhill.
2. **Some managers are dedicated to self-sacrifice and self-denial.** When clients are blended with these types of parts, their attention is permanently fixed outward. They are always trying to discern the needs of others and oversee the welfare of someone else—anyone else!—but themselves. They sacrifice for partners, children, parents, bosses, and coworkers. These manager parts often began their job at a very early age, in homes with nominal parents who were too preoccupied with their own addictive practices to take care of anyone. When we help the client notice and listen to these parts, we find out who the caretaker part is protecting, and then we can validate its generosity and devotion.
3. **Managers can be extreme.** Once a client's system is entrenched in addictive processes, managers become ever more unyielding. Inner critics, judges, perfectionists, caretakers, logical thinkers, and minimizers take over and keep the client afloat by operating from the neck up. They aim to accomplish basic tasks and mute vulnerable emotions like sadness, loneliness, and despair. They sling contempt, express disgust, insist on perfection, magnify every broken intention as a sin, and stigmatize firefighter compulsions to the nth degree.
4. **Managers reflect the larger culture.** They soak up moralistic, culturally propagated fears about firefighter behavior. These attitudes make a tremendous contribution to their bias against firefighters, who they view as immoral, destructive, and in need of harsh discipline (Hari, 2015;

Hart, 2021). They condemn the character of firefighters with little attention to their motives and no interest in asking why. But despite their vitriol, managers mean well. Their biases come with the job of protecting exiles and go when the job ends.

5. **Managers have good intentions and reasonable fears.** They are allergic to chaos, insecurity, failure, and humiliation. Their fears run on two tracks: (1) Firefighters will get out of control and take over (*You'll use again. It will ruin everything. We'll lose our job!*), and (2) the system will be overwhelmed by the emotional pain of exiles. As a result, they work diligently to silence emotional pain and control firefighters. In a balanced system, however, they get real satisfaction from fulfilling expectations at work and in relationships.

Once you understand their motives and characteristics, you can befriend managers. We believe direct access is a good option for engaging overly responsible, frantic, shaming, and blaming managers. We simply ask them how they are trying to help. In addictive systems, critical managers are typically trying to prevent more of the chaos that firefighters engineer, but they struggle to see that firefighter parts are well-intended. When we say something like, "I hear how parts of you hate the using," they may reply, "No, I really hate it! I hate those out-of-control parts." If we ask these parts to move aside, they feel insulted. Therefore, we believe it is most effective to engage them by normalizing and validating their perspective: "Right, of course you don't like it." We ask about their massive reform efforts and validate the pride they felt when they could make the changes stick. At the same time, we promise them that we can help those stubborn firefighter parts if they will permit.

After engaging with the manager team, we review and highlight the addiction polarity with metaphors. For example, we may describe how managers are trying to take charge in a classroom of unruly kids or keep a boat afloat in stormy waters. We underscore the impossible nature of their balancing act with firefighters, with each side escalating and no one seeing the exit ramp. We commiserate with managerial exhaustion. We promise that exiles who are behind the scenes can be helped.

Next, we help managers unblend by asking the client how they feel toward the manager. Curiosity, kindness, compassion, and a collaborative stance are the golden keys to manager cooperation. They want relief from isolation, oppressive responsibilities, and fears—and an assurance that we are not trying to replace them. Managers like control. They do not want to leave their post when all hell could still break loose. If we appreciate their strengths and promise not to hamper them, they are more likely to accept our support. We ask them to consider, "What if you didn't have to handle this alone? What if the Self could help with the risk-taking firefighter parts?"

Throughout this process of befriending, we interrupt manager rants as they arise. When a shaming, contemptuous manager takes over, we interrupt its tirade promptly and guide the client to notice its harsh language. Even parts who rant repetitively in sessions are just doing their job. We point this out, acknowledge the part's ability to do its job well, and ask it to take a break and be more direct. Would it be willing to tell us exactly which part it feels the need to attack? What does it fear would happen if it stopped going after that part?

In addition, we help managers understand firefighter behaviors. Before firefighters are willing to speak for themselves, we explain to managers that firefighters are more complex than they appear. Managers know all the pain, stress, disconnection, and loss the client has faced. We insist that firefighters have always aimed to relieve or divert from that pain and stress. And we say that the Self, *the one who listens to everyone*, is now here to help.

Finally, we invite the manager team to plug into a new paradigm. They know their hard work has backfired over and over. They know that shaming evokes shamefulness and vulnerability, which feeds right back into that firefighter craving to soothe and medicate. They like the Self's patience and persistence, so we suggest a new way of doing things. What if instead of wrestling firefighters to the floor, managers allowed the Self to invite firefighters to the table where they can all break bread? What if instead of shaming firefighters, managers allowed the Self to offer the firefighter parts a safe haven and help the exiles they protect?

As we model this new way of being, we ally with managers. To this end, it helps to let them know two things: (1) *No one can control you*. If managers decide to let the Self help out and don't like the results, they can always go back to their old job and do things their way. (2) *Firefighters have equally thankless jobs and feel equally stuck*. Just as a couple therapist needs to gain the trust of both partners to bring the temperature down, the client's Self keeps getting in the middle of the addiction polarity—redirecting protective parts away from their old roles and asking them to bring their concerns to the Self.

The following case example illustrates how to befriend a manager. Gina was a forty-six-year-old, Romanian American, divorced, heterosexual, cisgender mother who lived with her teenage daughter in a Midwest suburb. She came to this session worried about her increasing use of cannabis. As it turned out, her inner critic was concerned about much more than cannabis.

BEFRIENDING A MANAGER



Gina's Manager: I had a terrible week. I'm feeling really low. I basically just hate myself, and I'm sick of everyone at work and everyone in my family. I'm miserable. I feel like nothing we've been doing is helping.

Therapist: Oh, that does sound miserable. I'm sorry it's been so tough! I hear that you're just miserable. Or I might say it this way: I hear that you have parts who feel just miserable. When your parts are feeling miserable, yeah, it feels like nothing is getting better.

Gina's Manager: It's not getting better. It's really not!

Therapist: Yeah, I hear you, it feels like nothing is going right. Can you tell me more about what's been especially tough this week?

Gina's Manager: I forgot to do some important things at work because I'm an idiot. So, when I picked up my daughter, I was distracted, and then we got into a huge fight because she was being selfish and wouldn't listen to me. Then when she stopped talking to me and was holed up in her room, I decided to get high. The next morning, I felt like hell when I woke up. I couldn't believe I just gave in like that. It was so stupid!

Therapist: That is a lot.

The therapist stays neutral and interested.

Gina's Manager: And now I'm back to getting high every day. Sometimes all day! Which I hate. I was doing so much better a few weeks ago.

Therapist: Weed has had a starring role this week. I know that can feel scary because the urge to use was down before. Can I reflect all this back to you in parts language? (*Gina nods.*) I'm hearing that it's been painful at work and at home this week. And that the part who helps you get away from all that by getting high keeps offering you a break from the pain and stress. At the same time, your critic is having none of it. No excuses! It is just angry and hostile about you using cannabis so much again. Is that right?

Gina: (*Gina nods.*) Yeah, I guess it really is mad.

Therapist: So let's pause for a moment and take a few breaths together. How is it to hear that version of the week?

Gina's Manager: (*Gina closes her eyes.*) Like I said, I'm miserable. I hate that I keep doing this. (*She wipes away tears*)

Therapist: You mean the critic hates that the cannabis-using part has upped the ante like this, right?

The therapist highlights the manager-firefighter polarity.

Gina's Manager: Yeah, it's like I'm back to square one.

Therapist: Hmm, yes. The critic says you've made no progress at all, not if you're using like this! Does the cannabis-using part pay attention to the critic?

Gina: Yeah. And it disagrees!

Therapist: They do disagree. I wonder if that vulnerable, lonely exile is absorbing all this. How is she feeling?

The therapist asks Gina to notice the effect of polarized protectors on the exile.

Gina's Manager: I don't know. I'm so depressed.

Therapist: It can be hard to separate out. How about if we just listen to the critic for a minute? (*Gina reluctantly nods.*) How do you notice the critical part right now?

Gina: It's a furious voice in my head all the time.

Therapist: Can you hear it right now? (*Gina nods.*) Okay, let it know that you hear it and that you assume it has a very important message for you. Would it be willing to tone it down a little so you can hear the message better? We don't want it to go away, just ask it to give you enough space to listen. That way, it can also notice that you're listening. Tell it that you are the one who listens to everyone.

Gina: Okay. It's a little quieter. Not much though! It's just surprised to hear that I'm not the one getting high.

Gina describes a little unblending.

Therapist: That's right, you're the one who's here to listen. Ask how it's trying to help when it goes after your cannabis-using part.

Gina: It says that part is screwed up and out of control as usual. It will never quit. This has to stop! And I'm just getting worse. I keep messing up at work. And things with my daughter aren't good.

Therapist: Do you see its point? (*Gina nods.*) The cannabis-using part did step up when another part panicked about work. And the critic also seems upset with the part who got angry when things blew up with your daughter. It can get busy with all these parts! But reassure the critic that you are the one who listens. Let it know that you see how vigilant it is with any part who is not doing the right thing.

The therapist guides Gina to validate and stay in the middle, without taking a side.

Gina: It hears me.

Therapist: What is it afraid would happen if it didn't hammer out these harsh messages all the time?

Gina's Manager: That's obvious! My life will go totally off the rails. I'd fall apart again.

Therapist: We don't want that. How are you feeling toward the critic right now, as it tells you about its big job? It has all these other parts to watch and try to control.

Gina: I see how much it has to do! It never rests.

Gina is getting access to the perspective of her Self.

Therapist: What if it didn't have to do all this alone? What if you were in its corner and you two could help these other parts as a team?

Gina: It says it doesn't think I can handle it. I've never handled it before!

Therapist: Well, that is true. Stuff really falls through the cracks sometimes. But when that happened, it wasn't you. Other parts do run the show sometimes. What if, going forward, the critic didn't have to handle those parts all alone because you took on the big job of helping them?

Gina: Well, it says it would be fine if I do. But it has huge doubts.

Therapist: Of course. Trust takes time and evidence. Do you want to stay connected and build that trust? (*Gina nods.*) Would the part like to have a relationship with you and see how you'd handle those parts?

Gina: Yes. It wants help. It is actually exhausted. It would be good if I could somehow help those parts. (*She sighs audibly.*)



Gina arrived at therapy feeling miserable after a week of dropping the ball, being on edge, arguing with her daughter, and using a lot of cannabis. In IFS parlance, she had a *parts attack*. As her protectors escalated, she felt out of control again. When she used impulsively after a tough day, the critic went on the warpath in a thankless effort to shame her firefighter part into reforming. Unfortunately, this amplified her exiles' sense of worthlessness and motivated her firefighter to lean more heavily on the calming effects of cannabis. Since the critic's desperate efforts to control the firefighter were making matters worse, the first order of business in this session was to help it feel less alone and more connected to Gina's Self.

As Gina illustrates, we can facilitate dialogues with insistent critics. First, we ask them how they're trying to help. Critics in addictive systems typically want to prevent more of the chaos and disasters that firefighters engineer, which is surely positive. As the manager team unblends and develops an ongoing, trusting connection with the Self, we can guide the client to ask some pointed questions, ever so lightly and with affection. As hard as these managers work, have they managed to fix or even discourage firefighters? The client often gets a rueful acknowledgment that their tactics haven't worked, so plan B might be a good idea. As this path opens, the client turns their attention back toward firefighters with the curiosity and calm of Self-energy.

QUESTIONS THE THERAPIST CAN ASK CLIENTS ABOUT THEIR CRITICAL MANAGERS

- Where does this critic show up in the body?
- What kind of energy does it have? How does it feel?
- Do you see it? If so, what does it look like?
- Do you hear it? If so, do you hear it inside or outside, and what does it sound like?

QUESTIONS CLIENTS CAN ASK THEIR CRITICAL MANAGERS

- Which part(s) are you attacking?
- Which parts worry you most?
- When you go after _____ part, how are you trying to help?
- What would happen if you stopped going after that part? Have you seen that happen before?
- What if firefighters are more complex than they seem? If you saw there was another way to help this firefighter so it used its energy in a better way, would that give you a break?
- If we could retrieve exiles and they could let go of their burdens, would you still have to work so hard?
- What do you want to say to me?
- How old are you?
- How old do you think I am?

- What would it be like if you could do this with me and didn't have to handle it alone?

REORIENTING BACK TO FIREFIGHTERS

As the client refocuses their attention back to firefighter parts, they might find that some are so walled off they seem to be on autopilot. Clients may believe that the urges and compulsivity of these parts hinder them from trying new options. In reality, though, these parts are not incapable of negotiating, nor are they permanently unreachable. They just haven't been reached yet. We can engage them with direct access.